Twisted Sister

By Lora Lee Cliff and Janet Wilson

INTRODUCTION

DR. BLANK: Therapy is often a place where one's "true self" can come out.
SR. CHERYL: Or should we say…"true SELVES?"
DR. BLANK: A nun gives her therapist insight into areas of her life even she isn't aware of.
SR. CHERYL: and a doctor hears every side of the story in…
BOTH: "Twisted Sister"
DR. BLANK: By Lora Lee Cliff and Janet Wilson.

**NOTE Dr. Blank can be played by either a man or woman*

(SR. CHERYL is lying on the couch clutching her purse while DR. BLANK is sitting in an easy chair. He blows the whistle.)

SR. CHERYL: *(As her thirteen-year-old self)* I'm thirteen and I just got my period. I've been crabby all day and didn't know why and boom my period started, first time. I thought God was punishing me for being crabby…

DR. BLANK: Go on, Sr. Cheryl.

SR. CHERYL: *(Sitting up and coming out of "character")* Dr. Blank, all I need is a little help sleeping. If you would just write me another prescription …

DR. BLANK: Go on with your dream.

SR. CHERYL: All right. *(Laying back on the sofa. DR. BLANK blows whistle. As her thirteen-year-old self)* I'm walking home from school and I just gotta have some candy it's all I can think about. *(Jumping up and looking in the "candy store window")* Then I'm at the candy store and

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

I see the butterscotch, and the chocolate-covered cherries. And then I see the chocolate mints and the chocolate creams! And I get really upset because then I don't know which I want more. And the lady's getting mad 'cause I'm taking a long time to decide. Anyway, I look up and there's Daddy and he smiles at me. Then, all of a sudden, he gets this weird look on his face and falls down. *(Running to the "door '')* So I run over to the door and it's locked I don't know how it got locked and I keep trying it and then I *(Running back to the "window'')* run back over to the window to see Daddy - and, and, and - he's laying on the ground and *(Running back to the "door* ") I run back to the door to try to get out and I'm screaming and kicking at the door *(Coming out of "character* ") and that's it.

DR. BLANK: It's great! It's a terrific dream because of all the symbolism - crabby and getting your period. I get this image of crabs. What a marvelous metaphor. I would love to work on this. Now, all you have to do is play out the different characters...

SR. CHERYL: What?

DR. BLANK: See, Sr. Cheryl, each character in your dream is an aspect of your personality - now, through exploring and tying up the fragmented selves ...

SR. CHERYL: *(Jumping up and heading for the door)* You're not going to tie me up! Why, Mother Superior ...

DR. BLANK: *(Intercepting her at the door with his hands up)* Oh no, no, no! Metaphorically speaking, metaphorically speaking! Oh hell, Sr. Cheryl, it's fun! Come on - you'll feel better. Why don't we start with your

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

father. Now, you're outside the candy store. What are you doing there? *(Blows whistle.)*

SR. CHERYL: I don't know about this.

DR. BLANK: Yes you do, Sister. *(Blows whistle again.)*

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Daddy," pacing back and forth)* Whew! I gotta have a break. Too much going on - the pressure! I need a drink, but Thelma won't like it. That Thelma - whoa! Guess I'll just have some candy. *(Dropping the "character ")* Is that what you mean?

DR. BLANK: Yes. Yes. Go on. Who do you see in the candy store?*(Blows whistle.)*

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Daddy")* Hi there, Cheryl! Isn't that funny? She looks kind of happy to see me. Come on, I'll buy you a Coke.

DR. BLANK: You seem very fond of her.

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Daddy")* Yeah. When she was a little girl, I used to hold her, read to her...

DR. BLANK: And now?

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Daddy")* I'm a very busy man. I don't have time for... Come on, Cheryl - now! *(Suddenly stricken with chest pains)* God, I don't feel well. Must have been that lousy goose liver I had for lunch. Cheryl, come on out here - you gotta call Mother.

DR. BLANK: Are you having a heart attack?

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Daddy')* I don't know! Would you just call my office?

DR. BLANK: I think we should call an ambulance.

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Daddy")* No, I'm fine.

DR. BLANK: You don't look fine.

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Daddy')* I told you to call my office.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DR. BLANK: Boy, you're stubborn, aren't you?

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Daddy')* I'm not stubborn. Where the hell is Cheryl?

DR. BLANK: She can't open the door. She's struggling with it.

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Daddy')* What's so hard about a little door? She had to open it to get in.

DR. BLANK: Can't you see she's trying?

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Daddy")* Just shut up and don't get into my business.

DR. BLANK: How dare you talk to me like that! What makes you so angry?

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Daddy")* For Christ's sake, what's a little door? These girls - just like their mother - can't do anything without throwing these little fits. Oh - don't start crying like that. Always crying, that one.

DR. BLANK: Aha! So it's her crying that pisses you off!

SR. CHERYL: *(Coming out of "character")* C'mon, Dr. Blank. You call this fun?

DR. BLANK: How insightful! The internalized father is incapable of taking in your feminine self thereby causing a polarization between your masculine and feminine selves.

SR. CHERYL: Forget it! Now just give me my prescription ...

DR. BLANK: *(Starts whistling "The Candy Man" and starts a "soft shoe" dance.)* I want to go back to the candy store - back to the sweetness. Now I want you to play one of the chocolates. *(He is about to blow his whistle but SR. CHERYL stops him.)*

SR. CHERYL: No. I'll be a peppermint patty 'cause that's the best. *(DR. BLANK blows whistle. SR. CHERYL as the "patty" jumping on the arm of the couch, crossing her legs and imitating Mae West; she "strips" off her sweater as she speaks.)* On top of my melt-in-your-little-mouth

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

chocolate, I have a flashy, shimmery, silvery paper wrapping. Shows you what a good taste I'll be. And over that one, there's a little cellophane wrap to make me very secure and never stale, you know, reliable every time.

DR. BLANK: Do you think you can do anything for Cheryl?

SR. CHERYL: *(As "patty")* Of course, honey - mmmm ... she's gonna love me. *(As "patty" to SR. CHERYL)* Hi there! Oh, you don't feel good, do you? Well, I'll fix that. Listen, I am so good. Now, undo my cellophane - *OK,* take away my silver lining - see, I'm all chocolate. Take a bite - the first time is great - that's it. See, I'm a little hard on the outside - ooh, surprise - I'm all white inside - that squishy, gooey, marshmallow - real, real moist...

DR. BLANK: Ahhh... fascinating ... the pieces of the subconscious are falling into place. There's a real paradox here. On the one extreme, there's this helpless child unable to accomplish a simple task, and then there's the adolescent's smoldering sexuality about to explode. I want to talk to your mother now. She's not exactly in the dream, but I want to talk to her anyway. Sit over here. Thelma, how do you feel about Cheryl growing up? *(Blows whistle.)*

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Mama" putting her sweater back on and buttoning it)* I do not look forward to having another teenage daughter. She's my favorite, but ... I told her when she was six, I said, "You were a lot nicer when you were three." And it's just gone on that way.

DR. BLANK: How does this change her relationship with her father?

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Mama* ") Her father's uncomfortable about things like this -

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

emotional things. I'll be able to handle her. She'll come to me like she always does.

DR. BLANK: So she'd rather come to you than to Daddy – I mean to her father?

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Mama '')* Oh heavens, yes. Her father thinks a period is a punctuation mark. They're not close.

DR. BLANK: Does Cheryl miss that?

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Mama '')* Oh no. I don't think it fazes her.

DR. BLANK: Are you sure about that, Thelma?

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Mama '')* Yes! Cheryl's father works hard. He's a good provider. And I see to it that his time at home is spent with me.

DR. BLANK: You are a selfish woman.

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Mama '')* You can't talk to me like that!

DR. BLANK: OK. Change places and be Cheryl. *(He attempts to blow the whistle but "Mama" stops him.)*

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Mama '')* Wait just a minute! I'm not finished yet!

DR. BLANK: *(Blows his whistle and points to the sofa; "Mama" refuses to budge; DR. BLANK blows several short sharp blows on his whistle and SR. CHERYL complies.)* Now Cheryl- is it true what your mother said?

SR. CHERYL: No! Mama won't let me know Daddy 'cause she wants me to be her girl.

DR. BLANK: *(Pointing to where "Mama" is sitting)* Tell your mother that.

SR. CHERYL: No! I'm not telling her anything. *(Standing up and holding out her hand for the prescription)* Just give me my prescription and let me go!

DR. BLANK: I'm offering you this creative process in order for you to discover

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

who you really are, and all you want is more pills. I'm so disappointed! Come on, Sr. Cheryl. You can play Mama again. *(SR. CHERYL resumes her "Mama" position.)* You seem a little upset. *(Blows whistle.)*

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Mama '')* What else can a mother do? What can a mother do? The sacrifices I have made for her. Her sisters did not get the dancing lessons. They did not get a lot of the things she did. She can just go off with her father - be his girl and leave me alone.

DR. BLANK: What are you feeling right now?

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Mama")* Betrayed. The last of my three blessings has betrayed me.

DR. BLANK: The missing link - betrayal. The fact that you're wanting to separate from the symbiotic relationship, but *she* just won't let you!

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Mama")* What are you talking about?! *(Grabbing her purse and beating DR. BLANK with it)* Just who do you think you are?

DR. BLANK: *(Blocking her blows with his arms)* I think we've done enough for one session, Sr. Cheryl.

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Mama," still beating him)* You have a lot of nerve sticking your nose in where it doesn't belong!

DR. BLANK: *(Still defending himself)* The session is over! *(He blows his whistle.)*

SR. CHERYL: *(Ignoring the whistle, "Mama" yanks the whistle out of his mouth and tries to cram it down his throat.)* All my daughter wants is a few lousy pills so she can sleep at night. *(DR. BLANK searches for his prescription pad.)* Is that asking too much? But no! You have to go dragging me into this! Why is it always the mother's fault? And I wasn't even in her damn dream...

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DR. BLANK: *(Quickly writing her a prescription)* Here it is! *(Fearfully hands it to "Mama.")*

SR. CHERYL: *(As "Mama," snaps it out of his hand.)* I'll give this to Cheryl and I'll be back for more!

DR. BLANK: Yes, yes, next week. *(As "Mama" exits, DR. BLANK throws himself on the couch.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lora Lee Cliff and Janet Wilson
Book: Play it Again (ed. Norman Bert)
ISBN: 978-0916260972
Publisher: Meriwether Publishing
Date (Month/Year): March 1993

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY